



POWER COUPLE: The least political prime minister and the most powerful politician work in tandem

ister to get funds approved for some of their pro-poor projects. "She is the last socialist in the Congress," declares Aiyar.

On economic issues, however, her reactions are dictated mostly by populism. She asked for a rollback in the petroleum price hike only after a public uproar and urged the prime minister to rethink foreign direct investment (FDI) in retail to safeguard the interests of small shopkeepers. Says a cabinet minister, "She does not play a file-pushing, appointment-fixing role."

Making politically-correct noises is all very well but Sonia is yet to deliver the big picture. Electorally, the party is going through a drought. The Congress has won four state elections since it came to power in 2004 (of these, while Assam and Maharashtra are intact, it has since lost Karnataka and Goa is on a weak wicket). The party has also lost three states—Punjab, Uttarakhand and Kerala—and barely managed to hold on to its tally in Uttar Pradesh. Sonia

has been told by her party strategists that she has a strong chance of wresting Gujarat from BJP.

Her control over the party is absolute. A party general secretary remarked somewhat self-deprecatorily that Sonia rules via a duffer group and a buffer group. The former comprises henchmen who rush to implement her bidding; the latter consists of advisors Sonia seeks out from time to time.

Still, she does not blatantly encourage cronyism. When she took over as party president, there were several power centres all vying for proximity to 10 Janpath. But the only 'confidant' who has survived is the low-profile Ahmed Patel, political adviser to the Congress president. The Congress party office that used to be a power centre during Sitaram Kesri and Narasimha Rao regimes has been dismantled and filled with

men with no mass base. The two former chief ministers, Ashok Gehlot and Digvijay Singh who are the only general secretaries with some sort of a base, have been reined in to handle administrative jobs. Perhaps, Sonia has learnt from Rajiv's and Indira's fear of regional chieftains.

The new Mrs G is still learning. Wrote Indira's biographer, "Sonia reportedly studied videos of her mother-in-law's speeches. She also dramatically adopted Indira's style and mannerisms. Her hair colour

deepened from light to dark, nearly black brown. She wore saris reminiscent of Indira's and took to wearing a man's large wrist-watch, just as Indira had." The original was a sorceress of the mass mind. The new one has a lot more rehearsals to do.

with Satarupa Bhattacharya and Subhash Mishra

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